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Going different ways? Right-wing parties and the immigrant issue in Denmark and Sweden

Christoffer Green-Pedersen and Pontus Odmalm

ABSTRACT This contribution analyses centre-right parties' attitudes and positions on immigration and integration in Denmark and Sweden. Despite the two countries being socio-economically and culturally similar, there are some significant political and structural differences which help to explain why immigration has played a much more prominent role in Danish politics compared to Swedish politics. The article argues that this can be explained with reference to, on the one hand, the stability of bloc party politics and, on the other, the extent to which centre-right parties have exploited 'the immigration issue' as a profiling tool. The findings suggest that even though Denmark has adopted a much tougher stance on immigration and integration compared to Sweden, the political climate in the latter has also undergone a number of changes in the past decade which have allowed centre-right and radical right parties to use immigration to challenge the prevailing cross-party consensus on the issue by suggesting a more market-oriented integration policy.

KEY WORDS Denmark; immigration; integration; radical right-wing parties; right-wing parties; Sweden.

INTRODUCTION

There are several reasons why Sweden and Denmark would approach questions relating to immigration and integration in a similar fashion. For a long time, both countries were (or at least perceived themselves to be) relatively homogeneous nation-states in terms of ethnicity. Both countries also have large, universal welfare states combined with a highly regulated labour market that limits job opportunities for low-skilled workers. During the 1970s and 1980s, there were also many similarities in terms of migration and migrant policy, which was based on a broad, cross-party consensus. However, by the early 1990s, the two countries started to diverge significantly as both Danish policy and the rhetoric surrounding it became notably more restrictive compared to Sweden, especially with regard to immigration.

The main argument of this contribution suggests that the explanation for this divergence should be sought in the differing positions of centre-right parties in

the two countries. The more restrictionist position of the Danish centre-right parties has been central in turning immigration and integration into a highly salient and contested policy issue which has also contributed to significant policy changes. Elements of this development can also be found in Sweden, but the changes in the position of the Swedish right and subsequent policy changes have generally gone in a different direction from Denmark. In addition, the diverging positions of centre-right parties can be explained by looking at the coalition incentives of the centre-right parties in the two countries. As we go on to show, these differences relate to differences in the composition and strength of the right-wing blocs in the two countries. The Danish centre-right parties have traditionally been much stronger electorally than their Swedish counterparts, yet, as a coalition bloc, they are significantly less stable. Consequently, the Danish centre-right has had to rely on, and sometimes co-operate with, radical right-wing parties which has placed the two dominant right-wing parties in Denmark – the Liberals (Venstre) and the Conservatives – in a different strategic position from their Swedish counterparts, the Liberal Party (Folkpartiet) and especially the Conservatives (Moderaterna). The main argument of this article thus strongly supports Bale's contention that understanding the policy position of centre right-wing parties is crucial to understanding both the development of immigration and integration policy and the rhetoric surrounding it (Bale 2008).

The argument is constructed in several steps. We start by presenting the composition and strength of the right-wing blocs in the two countries. The difference between the two countries in this regard is a key factor in understanding the development in immigration politics¹ in the two countries. We also lay out the similarities in the societal context with regard to immigration and proceed to describe the similarities between the two countries until the early 1990s. We then turn to an analysis of how the centre-right parties and their positions have shaped both policy and rhetoric with regard to immigration politics in the two countries during the 1990s, causing the divergence between the two countries.

THE NATURE OF POLITICAL COMPETITION IN SCANDINAVIA

In the Scandinavian context, political contestation has traditionally revolved around competition between the bourgeois parties on the right, or the bourgeois bloc, and the strong Social Democratic parties on the left.² However, in both countries, the more centrist of the right-wing parties – the Social Liberals in Denmark and the Centre Party in Sweden – have often supported the Social Democrats.

In Denmark, the major right-wing parties are the Liberals, a former agrarian party which has developed into a mainstream right-wing party, and the Conservatives, which is a traditional conservative party with an upper-class background. In practical politics it has often been difficult to distinguish between the two parties, though there has been a tendency for the larger of the two to

be more centrist while the smaller has had a more pronounced right-wing profile. The third traditional right-wing party is the Social Liberal Party, which is a centre-right party, coincidentally also with an agrarian history. The Social Liberals have, however, been more left-wing when it comes to certain non-economic issues such as defence policy. Since 1973, radical right-wing parties have also been represented in the Danish parliament. The Progress Party held seats until the 2001 election, while the Danish People's Party, which broke away from the Progress Party in 1995, emerged as the major radical right-wing party in the 1998 election.³

In Sweden, the bourgeois bloc has historically contained the traditional Conservative Party (Moderaterna), the traditional Agrarian Centre Party (Centerpartiet), and the Liberals (Folkpartiet).⁴ In the 1991 election, the Christian Democrats gained representation for the first time which increased the bourgeois bloc to four parties. From 1991 to 1994, the radical right-wing party, New Democracy (Ny Demokrati), was represented in the Swedish parliament, but otherwise Sweden has had no radical right-wing party at the national level.

The difference in representation of radical right-wing parties is an obvious point that distinguishes the two countries. However, two further differences are worth mentioning. The first is that the right-wing bloc has always been stronger in Denmark. With the exception of a few shorter periods, the bourgeois bloc in Denmark has controlled the majority in the Danish parliament. On the occasions where the Social Democrats have led governments, this has been primarily due to the Social Liberals 'defecting' from the bourgeois camp. In Sweden, bourgeois majorities have been the exception to the rule and have always been followed by Social Democratic majorities. The second difference is that the point of gravity in the Danish right-wing bloc has always been towards the two sister parties, the Liberals and the Conservatives, which have been much stronger than the Social Liberals. In Sweden, the more centrist of the centre-right parties (the Liberals and the Centre Party) have most of the time been equal to the Conservatives in strength (Arter 1999). In the 1990s, these differences constituted different strategic contexts for the right-wing parties with regard to the immigration issue. These background settings thus help to explain why Danish and Swedish immigration politics began to diverge in the 1990s.

THE SOCIETAL CONTEXT

The two countries share many societal similarities which suggests strong similarities in the way that centre-right parties would respond to, and position themselves on, immigration and integration issues. First, the two have been relatively homogeneous in terms of ethnicity,⁵ partly owing to the lack of a colonial past and partly owing to being late starters as countries of immigration. Second, both countries have highly developed welfare systems which provide generous and tax-financed benefits based on the principle of universalism with access to benefits without prior labour market participation. This welfare state is

combined with a labour market where high minimum wages were meant to crowd out low-paid jobs in the private service sector which, in other countries, are exactly the type of jobs that would be open to low-skilled immigrants. This combination of high minimum wages, generous social benefits and high barriers of entry to the labour market has in many cases led to migrants ending up with low labour market participation and high dependency on social benefits. Thus low-skilled immigration can be expected to add to, rather than alleviate, financial problems in universal welfare states like Denmark and Sweden (Nannestad 2004). One noticeable difference, however, is the different share of immigrants in the population. In Denmark, the share of the population with a foreign background is 6.2 per cent where the similar figure for Sweden is 10.9 per cent (Green-Pedersen and Krogstrup, forthcoming). Finally, in terms of public opinion, there are many similarities between the two countries. In both countries, public opinion provides right-wing parties with an incentive to promote a restrictionist approach since it would be in line with the majority of the electorate (cf. Green-Pedersen and Krogstrup, forthcoming).

IMMIGRATION POLITICS AND POLICY IN THE 1970s AND 1980s – EXPECTED SIMILARITIES

Since the 1970s, migration flows to Denmark and Sweden have consisted primarily of asylum-seekers and family reunification (Freeman 1992; Gaasholt and Togeby 1995). This was due to an official stop on labour migrant recruitment introduced in both countries in the early 1970s. The broad consensus in both countries on halting labour immigration was a consequence of the regulated labour market and the strong influence exercised by the trade unions. The strong opposition to further migration from the trade unions, especially in Sweden, related to the privileged employment position that labour migrants enjoyed compared to other countries. This included the same social and economic rights as native workers which was said to be undermined by further, unregulated, labour migration (Geddes 2003).

The ease with which immigration policy was altered in Sweden can be attributed to the strong corporatist arrangements prevailing at the time, i.e. the close relationship between the state, trade unions and employer federations and the emphasis on full employment. The famous Swedish model for integration (Soininen 1999) was put into effect in the mid-1970s, having been preceded by an extensive government inquiry. This investigation proposed a new direction for the social, political and cultural status of migrants which, by international standards, was of a generous nature. The new guidelines put immigrants in a privileged position in terms of having access to rights and entitlements on a par with Swedish nationals (Borevi 2002). Although much praise has been given to the Swedish multicultural model (Castles and Miller 2003), it was also subject to significant criticism and debate by scholars and political actors in Sweden (Pred 2000; Ålund and Schierup 1991). The reasons for this can be summarized as follows: (a) perceived failure of multicultural policies; (b) increased

socio-economic exclusion of foreign-born residents and their descendants; and (c) stigmatization and stereotyping. However, issues relating to immigration and integration were, up until the 1990s, characterized by a remarkable degree of cross-party consensus, explained in part by the strength of the Social Democrats, relatively low levels of immigration and high levels of labour market participation.

In Denmark, it was not until the early 1980s that immigration became a political issue at all (Hamburger 1989). A key turning point came in 1983 when a broad majority in parliament, with the exception of the radical right-wing Progress Party, passed a new, and in many ways, more liberal immigration law. The opportunities for family unification were strengthened, asylum-seekers achieved more rights, and expulsion of foreigners became more difficult (Brøcker 1990). In many ways, the debate on this more liberal immigration law, which had been prepared by an expert commission, continued along the lines of the 1970s discourse, but critical voices from the right-wing parties had become stronger. The Progress Party had strongly opposed existing policies since its entry into parliament in 1973 and also launched a number of xenophobic campaigns. More remarkable perhaps was the declaration by the Conservative Minister of Justice, Mr Erik Ninn Hansen, that the law would threaten Danish nationality. This declaration provoked strong reactions from the left-wing opposition (Jensen 2000; Brøcker 1990).

At the same time as the new law was implemented, an increasing number of refugees from the Middle East started to arrive in Denmark. This sparked a public debate where politicians from both the Conservatives and Liberals followed the critical immigration line introduced by the Minister of Justice (Jensen 2000). The new position included a revision of the law which tightened the conditions for asylum in Denmark (Brøcker 1990). In the end, the government managed to get its proposal passed in parliament relying on support from the Social Democrats, but without the support of the Social Liberals. After that, the issue more or less disappeared from the party political agenda during the remainder of the bourgeois minority government (Green-Pedersen and Krogstrup, forthcoming).

The debate in the mid-1980s showed that politicians from both the Liberals and the Conservatives wanted their parties to change direction towards tighter immigration controls and an integration policy that was more demanding for immigrants. Nevertheless, the broad party consensus around immigration politics survived. The reason for this was the special character of Danish coalition politics during this period. A parliamentary majority, including the Social Liberals, but not the government parties, existed in this period with regard to non-economic issues, especially foreign policy, justice and the environment (Damgaard and Svensson 1989). A more restrictionist position by the Liberals and Conservatives was thus a political dead-end because it would have sharpened the already existing conflict with the Social Liberals and could have threatened government survival.

Although comparatively more prominent in Denmark, immigration could by the end of the 1980s still be considered to be a minor political issue and the

right-wing parties in both countries were still part of the broad national consensus on the issue. Policies in both countries had, however, moved somewhat in a more restrictionist direction and the consensus had showed signs of cracking in Denmark.

THE 1990s: GOING DIFFERENT WAYS?

Compared to Denmark, Sweden was in this respect lagging behind. Immigration became a hot and contested political issue 'only' in 1991 when the surprise success of the populist party, New Democracy, moved immigration up the agenda. Although New Democracy's success, as a party, was short-lived, the effects of its restrictive stance on immigration can today be found in mainstream politics. The repercussions of its proposed policy changes were present in subsequent elections as well as in the turn away from explicit multiculturalism in recent years. A telling example is the issue of language competency for naturalization. In 1992, New Democracy proposed that knowledge of Swedish should be a requirement for migrants wishing to become Swedish citizens. Their proposal was unsuccessful at the time, having been blocked by both left- and right-wing parties (Sveriges Riksdag 25/11/1992). However, in 1997 the Conservatives presented a very similar proposal which was subsequently picked up by the Liberal Party in their election campaign in 2002. The absorption of radical right policies and the mainstreaming of these are in Swedish politics symptomatic of how immigration and integration have gone from being a general welfare state concern, characterized by cross-party consensus, to being an issue used as a way of distinguishing and profiling parties.

This development had already gone one step further in Denmark where the incentives for making immigration a political issue had increased in the early 1990s and more particularly following the change of government in 1993. The Social Liberals now entered a coalition with the Social Democrats, the Christian Democrats and the Centre Democrats, the former having governed with the Liberals and Conservatives from 1982 to 1988. This new constellation put the parties in a very different situation compared to the 1980s, when they were in government. They now had no reason to avoid confrontation with the Social Liberals. Further, their major chance of getting back into government was to win a majority together with the Progress Party which diminished the need for the parties to distance themselves from the xenophobic rhetoric of the latter.

From 1993, the Danish Conservatives, and especially the Liberals, started to change their policy positions quite dramatically with regard to both immigration and integration. The first sign of this came in 1994 during a debate on how to deal with Bosnian asylum-seekers. The government, supported by the left-wing parties, wanted to allow the Bosnians to be granted refugee status. On the other hand, the right-wing opposition proposed temporary residence permits which meant repatriation to Bosnia once the war was over. The government was able to pass its proposal in parliament, but the debate showed that the

right-wing parties had changed course, and thus abandoned the consensus around the immigration issue (Jensen 2000). However, in 1995, the Progress Party was splintered and the Danish People's Party emerged with the very popular leader, Pia Kjaersgaard. As mentioned above, the Progress Party had made immigration one of their key issues. The Danish People's Party focused almost exclusively on immigration and furthermore appeared as a much more reliable party, both in the eyes of the electorate and as a coalition partner, compared to the Progress Party which had constantly been plagued by internal disagreements and its eccentric leader, Mogens Glistrup. Finally, the Danish People's Party was also very keen to distance itself from any neo-Nazi groups and connections (Rydgren 2005a). The populist right became significantly stronger after the Danish People's Party had established itself in the Danish party system at the 1998 election when it won 7.4 per cent of the vote.

The pattern of confrontation between the government and the right-wing opposition was sharpened further after the 1998 election. The Liberals, under their former leader, Uffe Ellemann Jensen, had been reluctant to focus on immigration issues, but the new leader, Anders Fogh Rasmussen, realized that immigration could become a central point in the strategy of the Liberals to win government power. (Green-Pedersen and Krogstrup, forthcoming). Looking at the period from 1993 to 2001, the change in the position of, especially, the Liberals in Denmark is striking. In the party programme from 1995, they still focused on the right of immigrants to, for example, preserve their original culture (Venstre 1995), whereas in 2006 the focus is on what Danish society should demand from immigrants both culturally and economically (Venstre 2006). Another illuminating example was the question of the naturalization of immigrants. Until 1993, only the Progress Party had wanted to reopen the debate on this law, which had previously been passed in parliament without much controversy. However, from 1993, the Liberals and Conservatives also started to question the legislation (cf. Holm 2005: 93–113).

Developments in Sweden were generally different though with some similarities to Denmark. Although immigration and integration had been reasonably important issues for the electorate since the 1980s, they had not been crucial in determining party choice (Rydgren 2002). The mainstream parties, and especially those on the centre-right, had furthermore been slow to respond to changes in voter preferences and had not actively pursued the more right-wing voters (Rydgren 2005b). However, a turning point regarding the salience of immigration questions in Swedish politics and the stability of cross-party consensus on these issues came in the 1994 election. As in Denmark, the war in the Balkans had led to a dramatic increase in asylum applications which coincided with the Swedish economy's attempt to recover from the recession. These events prompted the election campaign to be dominated by questions of Sweden's commitment to refugee reception and, especially, the societal costs related to this type of migration. The change in issue preference can partly be attributed to the influence of New Democracy in shaping the agenda during the early 1990s and to the aggressive fashion in which they had pursued these issues.

The question of whether to restrict asylum and refugee migration was a key element in the election campaign as well as in the political debate in 1994. Relatively less attention was paid to issues of racism, discrimination and socioeconomic exclusion (Boréus 2006). Why parties avoided addressing these issues is puzzling since, as Rydgren (2004b) points out, during the economic recession of the 1990s, Sweden had one of the highest levels of unemployment amongst non-European migrants within the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development.

Following on from the increased political hostility towards immigration and the perceived failure of the multicultural project, an expert committee was set up to formulate a new direction for Swedish integration policy. *The politics of integration* presented in September 1997 put forward some new guidelines for what had previously been considered 'the politics of immigrants'. A distinguishing feature of these policies was a move away from the corporatist orientation of previous policies that considered 'immigrants' to be yet another type of social grouping in a similar vein to 'labourers' or 'employers'. Instead, the new policy would focus more on the individual and his or her needs. Linguistically this change could be seen in the emphasis on 'integration' as opposed to 'immigrants' and a focus on providing equality of opportunities (Göransson 2005).

This new deal also prompted the birth of the Swedish Integration Board (Integrationsverket IV) which had the overall responsibility for ensuring that the visions and goals of Sweden's integration policies have an impact in different areas of society. An indication that immigration, yet again, was to be a hot political issue came prior to the 1998 election when a former employee of the Swedish Board of Immigration, Kenneth Sandberg, spoke out about the 'disastrous situation' that Sweden was in after decades of 'mass immigration' which generated intense media coverage. The relatively open climate that had emerged, which allowed commentators to speak out in a covertly racist language, can again be attributed to the influence that New Democracy and its populist rhetoric had in the early 1990s (Rydgren 2005a). Although this new policy direction by and large corresponded to key centre-right ideas of individualism and equal opportunities, the Conservative Party responded to the (primarily Social Democratic) policy by issuing a distinctly more radical proposal in time for the 1998 election. The rhetoric of the far-right had been absorbed and mainstreamed into the Conservative's Party manifesto of 1997, *Land for Hoppfulla* (Land of the Hopeful). This was one of the first manifestos by a mainstream party to directly address 'the problems of immigration' and the Conservatives had picked up on anti-immigrant sentiments among the electorate as well as the support for radical right parties. However, the manifesto was heavily criticized for legitimizing this type of far-right discourse, seeing that the manifesto implicitly blamed immigrants for their high levels of welfare dependency and their 'failure' to integrate. Less publicized but just as controversial, was the Conservative proposal to re-open the borders for labour migration in order to remedy skill shortages in certain sectors.

This new fertile political environment also allowed the populist and right-wing Sweden Democrats to re-mobilize. After shedding their connections with neo-Nazi and other far-right groups they increased their electoral support and eventually gained seats in eight localities (Ekman and Larsson 2001). Their success can be explained by how the debate on asylum and refugees had shifted towards criticizing the Social Democrats' spending on settled refugees and whether the various integration projects were producing any beneficial results.

In Denmark, the period up until 2001 saw a constant battle between the bourgeois opposition – the Liberals and the Conservatives – and the centre-left government. By accepting some tightening of immigration and asylum rules and some tougher integration measures, the government tried to close down the issue as a major point of political conflict. However, the bourgeois opposition was very successful at turning immigration into a crucial – if not the dominant – issue in the 2001 election campaign. The politicization of the issue was thus a major reason for the bourgeois victory and move into government in 2001 (Andersen 2003). The election in 2001 allowed the Conservatives and the Liberals to form a coalition which could rule with support from the Danish People's Party. The need to avoid open conflict with the Social Liberals, which had constrained the two parties in the 1980s, was no longer present and the policy measures which the two parties had advocated in opposition could now be implemented. The policy measures related to both immigration and integration issues. With regard to immigration, the rules on family unification were tightened significantly, making them much tougher than in other European countries (Tænketanken 2004). Family unification before the age of 24 became virtually impossible and married couples had to document a closer connection to Denmark than to the homeland of the person not already living in Denmark. With regard to integration, the central idea had been that labour market participation was the best way to integrate immigrants. In terms of policy instruments, the focus had been on securing economic incentives for immigrants to take a job which corresponded with the more general transformations of Danish labour market policy. However, the Danish system provided fairly generous social assistance in which the actual net gain from working, compared to receiving social benefits, could sometimes be quite limited. A central measure was the introduction of a special level of social assistance for non-EU migrants which was considerably below the normal level and was intended to serve as an incentive for immigrants to accept low-paid jobs. These policy measures can be seen as the culmination of the Danish right's transformation of immigration and integration policy which took place after the change of government in 1993 and which brought the parties fairly close to the position of the Danish People's Party.

Although questions of immigration and integration had been prominent in previous Swedish elections, the 2002 election was significant for how the centre-right chose to utilize immigration and integration as a profiling tool. Ljunggren (2003) points to two particular circumstances that enabled

immigration to become one of the key election issues. First, as a way of pre-empting the Sweden Democrats from monopolizing the issue. The Sweden Democrats had closely monitored the success of the Danish People's Party and adopted a number of their tactics and policies which caused concern for the mainstream parties. Second, immigration, and especially criticism of the ruling Social Democratic bloc for incompetence in this area, served as an effective tool for profiling the centre-right parties. It also provided opportunities for the Liberal Party to put forward the issue of language tests as a requirement for naturalization. Although the proposal came under heavy fire from Social Democrats, relying on the rhetoric of equality and solidarity, it nevertheless corresponded, in parts, to the new integration directives from 1997. A key component of these policies suggested that integration should be the responsibility of the entire population, not just the receiving society. This indicated a significant shift towards the right when emphasizing the duties and responsibilities that migrants had and should adhere to if they wanted to integrate successfully. Although heavily criticized for being populist and fishing for the far-right vote, the Liberal Party was not opposed to Sweden's asylum and refugee policy as such, and was also in favour of a more flexible immigration system which allowed for future labour migration (Bale 2003).

The open attitude towards labour immigration was a continuation of what the Conservatives had already suggested in their 1997 manifesto and set the centre-right bloc apart from the left and the trade union view that labour migration should continue to be restricted. The centre-right also took the opportunity to further criticize the left in general, and the Social Democrats in particular, for having pursued a politics of integration which in many ways had 'failed'. A particular point was made regarding the high levels of unemployment, overrepresentation in criminal statistics and poor performance in schools by migrants and their descendants (Boréus 2006). Similarly, the revamped and sanitized Sweden Democrats exploited immigration as a profiling tool and focused their campaign on emphasizing the perceived differences between 'Swedes' and 'immigrants', using what for them was the novel approach of stressing the cultural clashes to which migration, and especially Islamic migration, gave rise to rather than using the traditional far-right discourse of race (Ares and Diaz 2006).

The relative success that the Sweden Democrats had in the 2006 election can be traced back to how salient integration and immigration issues were for the mainstream parties. In contrast to previous elections, immigration and integration issues were not as prominent in the 2006 election. Although immigration, and especially integration, figured frequently in public debate, these issues were somewhat overshadowed by the unexpected agreement reached by the centre-right alliance ('Alliance for Sweden') on a number of policies (growth, education, foreign policy, the welfare state, the labour market and justice), thus making them a serious contender for government (Aylott and Bolin 2007). Furthermore, the Conservatives had learned from the 1998 election and adjusted their rhetoric to once again frame integration in a general and ideologically-compatible language. Consequently, immigration and integration slipped down the priority list.

The Alliance parties' manifestos were indicative of these changes, with immigration and integration policies being vaguely formulated and appearing towards the end of the party manifestos. The proposed solutions to 'integration failures' did, by and large, correspond to the ideological positioning of the parties. The Conservatives' manifesto, for example, suggested that integration is a matter best dealt with by the labour market and consequently the barriers to participation in this area were to be removed (www.moderaterna.se), a view which was supported by the Centre Party (www.centerpartiet.se). In a similar vein, the Liberal Party identified unequal access to the labour market as a key problem but went one step further by also emphasizing that migrants have duties as well as rights (www.folkpartiet.se).⁶ The lack of a clear cross-party strategy on how to confront far-right opponents, in combination with immigration and integration issues receiving a low priority, possibly played in favour of the Sweden Democrats, who managed to carve out a clear party profile in the 2006 election (Aylott and Brodin 2007). However, the shift in government structure in the 2006 election also marked a number of significant changes in terms of the Swedish approach to immigration and integration. Nyamko Sabuni, a Liberal Party member, was appointed as minister for integration and gender equality. Sabuni established herself as an important figure in the integration debate by quickly implementing the closing down of the Swedish Integration Board, a plan that had been hatched by the Alliance in the years running up to the 2006 election. The significance of this act should not be overlooked since it marks a clear disengagement from the Swedish model. Nevertheless, it was passed with remarkably little debate and controversy, although the Social Democrats and the Left Party criticized the decision for not being properly thought through. Further changes included emphasizing the importance of Swedish language education, combating discrimination and providing equal opportunities in the labour market.

CONCLUSION

The development of immigration politics in Denmark and Sweden since the 1990s shows a surprising degree of divergence given the similarities in societal context. In Denmark, the considerable changes in a more restrictive direction, which resulted from the politicization of the issue after the change of government in 1993, remain in place even though political attention to the immigration issue has cooled down somewhat since 2001. In fact, a new party consensus around these restrictive changes has emerged in Denmark as the Social Democrats have largely accepted them in an attempt to downplay the role of the immigration issue in Danish politics (see Bale *et al.* 2007).

The Swedish centre-right parties have not made a move in a restrictionist direction to anything like the same extent. For example, the Danish decision to restrict the immigration of dependants by raising the age limit for family reunification to 24 was viewed with scepticism in Sweden and there was no equivalent policy position by the Swedish right. The furthest move in

a restrictionist direction was represented by the Conservative position up to the 1998 election, but even that contained a suggestion to re-open the borders for labour immigration. Such a liberal element is not found in the positions of Danish right-wing parties in the 1990s. Furthermore, the Swedish Conservatives more or less gave up this partial move in a Danish direction before the 2006 election to secure the coherence of the 'Alliance' with the centre-right parties.

It is important, however, not to misinterpret this lack of movement as an indication of Swedish immigration politics today being largely similar to that of the 1980s. Sweden has in fact moved away from cross-party consensus on integration to a somewhat more polarized situation between the centre-right and the left blocs. Consequently, the Swedish model of integration has undergone extensive restructuring. However, the disagreement between the left and right in Sweden revolves mainly around whether the welfare state or the market is the most effective tool for reducing socio-economic exclusion. It is much less about the right wanting a more restrictionist immigration policy than in Denmark.

The argument of this paper suggests that the difference in right-wing positions in the 1990s, and the differences in immigration politics to which this led, should be explained by the differences in coalition politics of the right-wing bloc. In Denmark, the change of side of the Social Liberals in 1993 which led to a change of government implied that the major parties of the right – the Liberals and Conservatives – now had no incentive to avoid confrontation with the Social Liberals over the immigration issue. This was what had kept them from turning in a more restrictionist direction in the 1980s. During the 1990s, the two parties turned steadily more restrictionist as part of a very successful strategy to politicize the issue. This politicization, which also involved co-operation with the radical right, led to a much more restrictionist policy in Denmark with regard to both immigration and integration (Green-Pedersen and Krogstrup, forthcoming).

In Sweden, a similar move by the Conservatives would have been, and continues to be, dangerous because it would damage the right-wing bloc's chances of presenting itself as a united alternative to the Social Democrats. The U-turn of the Swedish Conservatives in the direction of the traditional consensus around immigration politics before the 2006 election illustrates exactly this. The U-turn was necessary to establish the right-wing 'Alliance', which in the end won power. The increased polarization between the left and right on integration policies fits well with the coalition politics of the right because it corresponds with the classic class cleavage which has been the main divider in Swedish society.

The experiences in Sweden and Denmark clearly show that analysing the position of the centre-right is crucial for understanding immigration politics and thus clearly confirms the central argument of this volume. Further, by stressing the importance of the centre-right, and not just the radical right, this contribution also argues that the tendency of the literature to emphasize radical

right-wing parties with regard to immigration and integration is problematic (Bale 2008). At the very least, the role of radical right-wing parties has to be seen in connection with the question of coalition politics of the entire right-wing bloc (Bale 2003). Radical right-wing parties have played a much stronger role in Danish politics but, as presented above, this difference only became important as part of Danish coalition politics during the 1990s. The presence of the Progress Party and its xenophobic rhetoric during the 1980s did not cause a break with the overall party consensus and thus a divergence from the Swedish situation. That break and that divergence only happened after 1993 when the coalition incentives of the centre-right in Denmark changed.

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NOTES

- 1 To make presentation easier, immigration politics in the following refers to both immigration and integration policies.
- 2 A more detailed introduction to the right-wing parties in Scandinavia and their development can be found in Arter (1999).
- 3 In 1973, two other small centre right-wing parties, the Centre Democrats and the Christian People's Party, also gained representation, which they have lost in recent years.
- 4 It is worth noting that the Swedish Liberals are much more of a centrist party than the Liberals in Denmark and as such are in many ways more similar to the Danish Social Liberals.
- 5 Although both countries have had linguistic minorities for centuries (Finnish and Saami communities in Sweden and the small German minority in southern Denmark), they have been subject to strong processes of assimilation over the years and have only recently been recognized as national minorities.
- 6 In comparison, the Social Democrats also pointed to the importance of the labour market but phrased this in traditional social democratic language of equality and inclusion (www.socialdemokraterna.se). The Left Party's manifesto, on the other hand, only mentioned immigration and integration indirectly when pointing out that it favoured a generous interpretation of the right to asylum. The Green

Party's manifesto contained a vague paragraph on the benefits of a multicultural society but this is, on the other hand, complemented by a very detailed list of policy proposals on their webpage. The Greens were also, somewhat surprisingly perhaps, in favour of free immigration (www.mp.se) as well as a generous asylum and refugee policy.

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